



AS MY CITY FALLS, I SHALL FALL WITH IT

THE FALL OF CONSTANTINOPLE (1453)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The Ottoman Empire

BEFORE

1071 Turkish forces inflict a significant defeat on the Byzantine Empire at the Battle of Manzikert.

1389 The Ottomans defeat the Serbs at Kosovo, making possible Ottoman advance into Europe.

1421 Murad II comes to the Ottoman throne and plans extensive conquests.

AFTER

1517 The Ottomans conquer Mamluk Egypt.

1571 The Ottoman navy suffers a crushing defeat at Lepanto.

1922 The empire ends with the foundation of modern Turkey.

In 1453, the Ottoman Turks attacked and took the city of Constantinople, the capital of the Byzantine Empire. The loss of this millennium-old Christian empire, which had once stretched virtually all the way around the Mediterranean, was a profound shock to the Christian world. As if to symbolize the Muslim victory Hagia Sophia, one of the greatest cathedrals in Christendom, was converted into a mosque.

The Ottoman Turks had already conquered much of the surrounding territory before Sultan Mehmed II (1432–1481) laid siege to the city and bombarded it with heavy artillery. Having breached its walls, his army of more than 80,000 men then overwhelmed the small force inside. Constantine XI, the last Byzantine emperor, was killed, and with the fall of the city, his empire ended. Constantinople then became the capital of the Ottoman Empire, which lasted until 1922.

A weakening empire

The Byzantine Empire was already in terminal decline by the time Constantinople was taken. It had shrunk to include only the capital city, some land to its west, and the southern part of Greece. The decline began at the Battle of Manzikert (1071), during which the army of the Turkish Seljuk dynasty drove the Byzantines out of their crucial territory in Anatolia. From this point, rival claims for the Byzantine crown, disputes over tax, loss of trade revenue, and poor military leadership all contributed to the contraction of the empire.

In 1203, the Fourth Crusade—a western European expedition originally intended to conquer Jerusalem—became entangled in the empire's politics. Some of the crusade leaders pledged to help restore the deposed Byzantine Emperor Isaac II Angelos in return for support for their expedition. They were initially successful: Angelos' son was crowned as co-emperor but, in 1204, he in turn was deposed by a popular uprising.